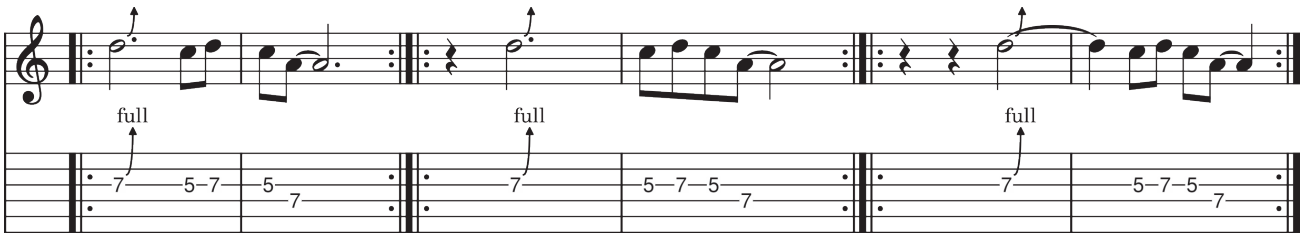
LESSON 19: RHYTHM CONCEPTS FOR LEAD GUITAR

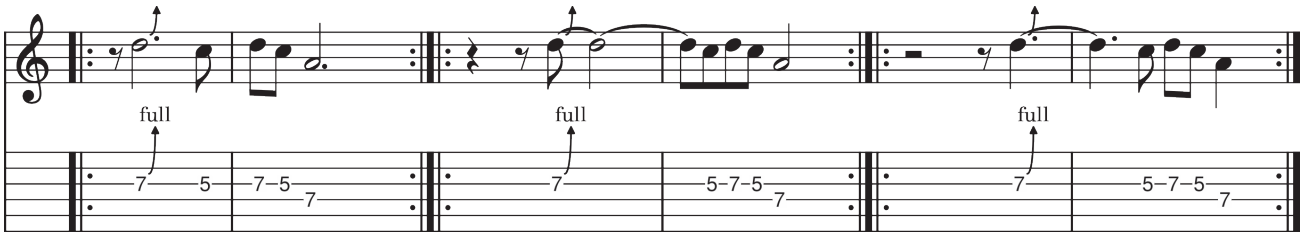
A lot of our training tells us to start on the 1 beat, but a lead or melody might sound more interesting if it starts late or early. Starting after the 1 beat can make it sound like you're "fashionably late" to the party and make your lead sound less predictable. Alternatively, coming in early (like an anacrusis) can help blend musical sections together more smoothly.

To get better at coming in with a lick on the "wrong beat," it's good practice to take a simple melodic phrase (or lick) and move it around in the measure so it begins in different places. This can drastically transform the overall feel of a phrase without editing its melodic content, and can prove a difficult challenge.

In the first two measures below, you'll see a simple blues lick that starts on the 1 beat. Repeat that over and over throughout a 12-bar blues to get used to its rhythm. Measures 3 & 4 shows the same lick, but the entire thing now starts a beat later (and begins on beat 2), and measure 5 & 6 shows the same lick pushed over to start on beat 3.



Let's try to offset that same lick so it begins on an upbeat (or off-beat). Three such examples are shown below:



One final piece of advice is to try restricting your lead playing to a specific rhythmic structure. Your melodic notes are free to change, but your rhythm pattern must always stay the same. Doing this usually makes improvised solos sound less "noodly" and more cohesive, as there is always an element of consistency at play. Then of course, by breaking this pattern, we can create great interest and intrigue. Consider the melody for "*Canon in D*" by Pachebel, how it consistently maintains the following rhythmic throughout: